what happens in the years ahead," says a TMC MP.

What may also go against AAP is that Delhi and Punjab account for only 20 Lok Sabha seats, while Bengal sends 42 members to the lower house and the two Congress-ruled states—Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh—send 37. Moreover, AAP's success in assembly elections has not been reflected in its Lok Sabha tally. In Delhi, it could not win a single seat in the past two general elections, and in Punjab, where it bagged 20 assembly seats in 2017, its Lok Sabha tally dropped from four in 2014 to just one in 2019. "It shows Kejriwal is not seen as an alternative to Prime Minister Narendra Modi," says Manoj Tewari, BJP MP from Delhi.

AAP's real test now will be the Gujarat assembly poll later this year, where it expects to convert the bipolar BJP-Congress contest into a three-cornered one. The BJP has not lost a single election—assembly or Lok Sabha—here in more than two decades. Though the Congress put up a tough contest in 2017, adding 16 seats to its assembly tally, the BJP made a clean sweep of all 26 Lok Sabha seats in both 2014 and 2019. "AAP's entry will only divide the anti-BJP vote, eventually helping us," says a Gujarat BJP leader who did not want to be named.

Besides Gujarat, 10 other states—Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Telangana, Tripura, Meghalaya, Nagaland and Mizoram—will go to polls before the 2024 general election. Together, they account for 146 Lok Sabha seats, of which the BJP occupies 121. Congress is the only party that challenges the BJP in all these states, except Telangana. In Gujarat, Himachal, Chhattisgarh, MP and Rajasthan, which account for 95 seats, it's almost a direct contest between the national parties. In Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh, Congress has been in power since 2018. It had also won the 2018 MP assembly poll with a thin margin. Yet, it could send only three MPs from these states in 2019.

For the grand old party, that is the existential challenge—in general elections, it has failed to present itself as an alternative to the BJP even in states where it is a direct challenger. State victories too have become rarer. Congress now occupies only 692 of the 3,933 assembly seats—17 per cent—across the country. Not surprisingly, there has been a growing murmur among its leaders, particularly veterans, for a change of leadership.

THE ONLY GLIMMER OF HOPE FOR THE OPPOSITION IS AAP'S LANDSLIDE VICTORY IN PUNJAB, WHERE IT WON 92 OF 117 SEATS

Though Sonia Gandhi is the party president, Rahul Gandhi remains the de facto head. Rahul and his sister Priyanka Vadra backed Navjot Singh Sidhu in his rebellion against Captain Amarinder Singh, who was forced to resign as Punjab CM. The wipeout in Punjab and UP—where Priyanka was party in-charge—will likely embolden the anti-Rahul faction. Detractors blame him for the debacle in Uttarakhand as well, where many political observers expected Congress to outperform the BJP.

"The Gandhi brand name has lost its USP. In Punjab and Uttarakhand, Rahul and his cronies were more interested in harassing veterans than strategising for victory. Priyanka was a non-starter in UP. It is time Congress got rid of the Gandhis," says a Congress Lok Sabha MP, adding that Rahul's return as party president in September is no longer a foregone conclusion. Former Union minister Shashi Tharoor has already asked for a change in the "organisational leadership".

Even likely allies are unwilling to accept Rahul as the face of an anti-BJP alliance. While Mamata declared the UPA's end, Sharad Pawar has said the Congress must introspect about its leadership and not aspire to be the leading force in the opposition alliance. Yet, even Pawar has accepted that the Congress's pan-India presence makes it the only party that can provide a national alternative to the BJP.

Indeed, electoral arithmetic makes the Congress indispensable. While it is in government in four states—three on its own and two as a junior coalition partner—the party is a key opposition player in 15 states. In Arunachal Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Himachal, MP, Rajasthan and Uttarakhand, there's a direct Congress-BJP contest. The Congress's abject failure in these states, where it won only four of the 102 Lok Sabha seats, has been a key factor behind the BJP's successive victories in general elections.

In Punjab, Assam, Karnataka, Kerala, Haryana, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Goa, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram and Nagaland, which account for 155 of the 543 Lok Sabha seats, the Congress can play a deciding role and distance from the party would mean further dividing the anti-BJP votes. Moreover, the party came second in 196 of the 403 seats it contested in 2019, though it could win only 52.

So, while the shape of the opposition alliance could be decided post-polls, its existence and success will depend on how various opposition parties perform in their respective strongholds in 2024. With little common ground, they will need to create an appealing narrative to convince voters that one of them could emerge as an alternative to Modi. ■